BOOKS ▼

Balancing Act

MAYUKH SEN HAS WRITTEN AN EMPATHETIC BIOGRAPHY OF **MERLE OBERON,** WHO MADE IT BIG IN HOLLYWOOD BY CONCEALING HER SOUTH ASIAN ROOTS



LOVE, QUEENIE: MERLE OBERON, HOLLYWOOD'S FIRST SOUTH ASIAN STAR
by Mayukh Sen
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What if you spend your whole life living a lie and do it so convincingly that you believe it too. That was the case with actress Merle Oberon (1911-79), born Estelle Merle O'Brien Thompson in Bombay. In her quest to make it to the magical world of Hollywood, Oberon hid her Anglo-Indian roots and claimed she was white and hailed from Tasmania, Australia. It's a lie she'd take to the grave.

In *Love, Queenie: Merle Oberon, Hollywood's First South Asian Star*—Queenie being the name she was bestowed by her non-white mother who posed as her sister—Mayukh Sen digs deep into the circumstances that compelled her to live a life of deception. He sets the background about her roots by detailing the ostracism Anglo-Indians faced in British-occupied India. He brings up the derogatory terms they were subjected to: "Blacky-white. Chee-chee. Kutch-abutcha (half baked). Eight annas (referring to the fact that there were 16 annas to a rupee)." He then paints a captivating portrait of a determined young woman who wouldn't let prejudice come in the way of her dream to be a famous actress. There she is in England acting on stage and then in films, only to set her sights higher by heading to the US. Only she was arriving when outsiders, especially those from South Asia, were not welcome.

Oberon cooked up a story that ensured she didn't face scrutiny about her racial heritage. In 1935, she was nominated for a best actress Oscar. After Michelle Yeoh won the Oscar in 2022 to headlines of being the first Asian nominee to do so, Oberon's name resurfaced as the actual first to break the glass ceiling and pave the way for others. Sen's gaze is empathetic as he packs in a punch of revelations, scandal and criticism, especially around her complexion, more so in the technicolour era. *Love, Queenie* ultimately is a tragic tale ripe for cinematic treatment, about a complex woman who achieved her ambition despite adversities. ■

—Suhani Singh

SPORTS ▼

AGAINST ALL **ODDS**

SAIYAMI KHER JUGGLES TWO HATS—ACTOR AND TRIATHLETE—WITH PANACHE, AS HER RECENT SUCCESS IN IRONMAN 70.3 SHOWS

During Saiyami Kher's first Ironman 70.3 in September 2024, she went 2 km off course on the bike route and had to retrace her steps. She missed out on adequate hydration, resulting in painful shin splints. But she pushed on to the finish, the last legitimate finisher. "The biggest muscle you train in a triathlon is your mind. I learned that no amount of fitness matters if you lose heart halfway," says Kher, 33.

She worked towards her goals and in early July, lined up for her second Ironman 70.3 in Jönköping, Sweden. She finished in 7 hours 29 minutes, improving on her best by over 30 minutes.



KHER WAS UP AGAINST **WIND, RAIN AND FRIGID WEATHER IN SWEDEN**, BUT IMPROVED HER PERSONAL BEST

The 10 months between the races needed a fine balance in time management. The actor would put in two hours of training before taking on a full day's filming schedule for *Jaat*. Besides training, she was also mindful about her diet, prepping most meals herself. "It used to get tiring, but it's about showing up when you don't want to. It all adds up," she says. On race day, Kher woke up to bitterly cold conditions. Her nerves jangled, until she noticed the smile on a visually challenged athlete. Nothing mattered from here on—neither the frigid waters of Lake Vättern, nor the rain and wind. When she made the finish, she realised she was ready to do it all over again. "These races... strip away ego and fear, they demand honesty. And I've found that in the discomfort, I come closest to myself," says Kher. ■

—Shail Desai